

STATE ACCOUNTABILITY

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lishment that has been systematically debilitated and rendered infirm through incessant and multiple acts of neglect, intentional harm and a political philosophy of abuse and abandonment. The cumulative impact is that each new terrorist outrage in India is ordinarily met with disarray and posturing, rather than with responses that demonstrate improving control, efficiency and capability. Worse, a wide range of pseudo-solutions are immediately articulated, while the fundamentals, simple as they are, are studiously and persistently ignored.

With dozens of dysfunctional Central agencies already in existence, for instance, we are abruptly informed that the problem of terrorism can only be addressed by a new federal investigative agency. This is essentially a diversionary ploy to channel the entire debate into the realm of fractious Centre-state relations and contentious constitutional amendments that, advocates of this 'solution' themselves admit, are high-impossible to resolve. The result, of course, is that the political leadership has found an alibi that lets them off the hook as far as immediate corrective action is concerned. Or, again, the most widely circulated and popular myth of all, we are wisely informed that 'development', and not the use of force or any conceivable operational improvements in the security and intelligence establishment, is the 'only solution' to terrorism.

But 'development' is not something you can order off a menu card; it is not the case that, for 60 years, successive governments have implemented policies that deliberately sought to keep the country underdeveloped, and, since realisation has now abruptly dawned on the present leaders of this benighted nation that 'development' is the 'solution', such development is quickly going to be attained. There is, in reality, no magic formula that is going to transform India into a well-governed, modern, equitable society with its entire population enjoying European living standards at any point in the foreseeable future. Poverty, acute deprivation, widespread under-employment and unemployment and endemic backwardness, compounded infinitely by growing incompe-

tence in governance and a steady deterioration in administrative capacities and penetration across wide regions of the country, will remain inescapable realities for large proportions of the Indian population for decades into the future. Substantial pools of grievances and hopelessness will, consequently, continue to exist in abundance, for extremist and subversive elements to tap into.

Where then, do the real solutions lie? What, precisely, is the 'great idea' that can transform the confusion, vacillation and incoherence of current policy into a tough and effective line that will give a fitting response to the challenge of terrorism?

The reality is that, while a 'great idea' may, on occasion, underlie excellence in certain fields, excellence is not realised, even in such cases, merely through the articulation of an exceptional idea. What India needs is to plug the crippling deficits in its policing and intelligence agencies, nothing more and, equally nothing less. Instead, on the rare occasion when the policy discourse actually focuses on the country's security vulnerabilities, there is overwhelming emphasis on the creation of special forces and institutions, rather than on fundamental and comprehensive improvements in existing ones.

The first and most crucial principal here is that you cannot have a first class counter-terrorism response within the context of a third class policing system. This should have been more than evident by now, but somehow fails consistently to register. Take, for instance, the case of the National Security Guard (NSG)—an elite special response unit set up principally for counter-terrorism. Despite excellent manpower profiles, training regimes and technology backups, the NSG has had, at best, a peripheral role in dealing with terrorism simply because of its location. Terrorists, unfortunately, do not strike where special forces stand ready to confront them, and in most cases, by the time special forces arrive at targeted locations, the mischief has already been done. Of course, the special skills cultivated in the NSG are not altogether wasted, and the contributions, particularly, of explosives' experts in the organisation and the national database

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POPULATION. THAT IS
INDIA'S MANPOWER
DEFICIT COMPARED TO
WESTERN RATIOS OF
250-500 PER
1 LAKH.